

Four Deck Canasta

Objective:

The game has four players divided into two teams. Each team tries to outscore the opponent through the course of four “hands”, each hand with increasing meld point requirements (see Meld Points below). The primary means of scoring is by forming canastas (partners combine cards for this).

A canasta is 7 (or more) cards of the same type (8s, Jacks, etc.) Each hand has minimum canasta requirements for a team to end a hand.

To Start:

Four regular card decks with Jokers well shuffled. Deal four piles of 15 cards and four piles of 11 cards. The remaining cards are placed in the center of the table and become the draw pile. The top card is turned over in a separate stack to start the discard pile. Each player starts with the 15 card pile.

- Wild - Deuces and Jokers. Up to three of these can be used to make a canasta.
- Red Threes - Set aside as drawn. Player draws a new card from the deck for each red three in the 15 card hand or drawn during play. No extra card for the red threes in the 11 card hand.
- Black Threes - Played to stop the next player from picking up the discard pile. There is a special point count for all threes. Threes are not used to make canasta's.

Card Points:

- Jokers: 50 Points
- Deuces: 20 Points
- Aces: 20 Points
- 8 through King: 10 Points
- 4 through 7: 5 Points
- 3s: Red, 100 points each; Black, minus 100 points if still in hand at the end of hand.

Meld:

A meld is a group of three or more cards working towards a canasta. Players hold all cards in their hand until they acquire enough points to play the meld or “go down”. The four hands have increasing point requirements to go down (50, 90, 120, then 150). Only one player on each team has to meld for each hand.

Playing a hand:

Players begin with the 15 card pile. One partner for each team initially acquires cards to “go down” by meeting the hand’s point requirement. After one partner goes down, both partners can play on those cards, attempting to get a canasta. Each partner must get a canasta before they are allowed to pick up their 11 card pile. A team then works to complete the required canastas as well as any canastas to increase their point total.

A player begins a turn by either taking two cards from the draw pile or picking up the entire discard pile. The discard pile may only be picked up if the player has TWO of the card shown on top in their hand. The player is then required to start a NEW canasta with these three cards. The discard pile option is nullified if the top card is a black three.

At the end of each turn, the player must discard one card. If a player cannot go down, their only option is to discard one card. If the player can go down or the partner already has gone down, the player can:

- Play on existing partial canastas
- Place down at least 3 cards toward new canastas
- “Burn” cards on completed canastas.

Note: There is no bartering of cards according to Grandjoan (acting proxy for Aunt Terry)

Required Canastas and their point scores:

- Sevens: Seven or more 7s (no wildcards allowed). 1500 Points
- Wild Cards: Seven or more wild cards (Deuces and/or Jokers). 2500 Points
- Natural: Seven or more of a card type with no wild cards. 500 Points
- Unnatural: Seven or more of a card type with up to 3 wild cards. 300 Points

Following completion of the required canastas, a team is allowed to go out. This is accomplished by ONE of the players completely playing and/or discarding all of the cards in the hand.

Note: A player is not allowed to go out if the teams’ minimum canastas are not complete.

When a player goes out, all of the points in the teammate’s hand count against their total, so it is courteous to task a teammate if it is okay to go out.

Counting points at the end of a hand:

- The team going out receives 100 points
- All cards still held are tallied. These cards count against the total.
- Using the card point values above, tally the total value of all cards on the table including red threes. Cards in canastas get counted twice - once for the canasta value and once for the card value.

Victory!

The team with the highest point total at the end of the four hands is the winner.